

EUROPE - CENTRAL ASIA

Widespread decline as legal protections erode

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Eastern Europe and Central Asia (EECA) remains in second-to-last place in the regional ranking of the 2026 World Press Freedom Index, while the European Union–Balkans zone has held onto first place despite a drop in journalism conditions.

With the exception of **Kosovo** (84th out of 180 countries and territories in the Index, +15 places since 2025), which saw an improvement despite remaining one of the lowest-ranking countries in Europe, press freedom in the Western Balkans is generally getting worse. Although **Albania** (83rd, -3), **Bosnia and Herzegovina** (90th, -4) and **Serbia** (104th, -8) aspire to join the European Union (EU), all three countries are hostile to journalism and vulnerable to propaganda. **Moldova** (31st) is still the only country in Eastern Europe that falls into the “satisfactory” category for press freedom. The average of each indicator in Eastern Europe and Central Asia has declined, particularly the legal one.

Flourish is disabled.

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Weaponising legislation to bring the media into line

Several converging dynamics explain this widespread decline in press freedom. The region increasingly resembles a vast experiment where established values are turned on their head and legislation is used to serve those in power at the expense of the right to inform. After more than a year of democratic crisis and crackdowns on protests and their coverage, **Georgia** (135th) has fallen 21 places in the Index. The adoption and enforcement of restrictive laws — particularly on “foreign agents” and media funding — and new barriers to accessing information point to a clear erosion of the rule of law. In **Armenia** (50th), where the state of press freedom is now classified as “problematic,” the drop in the legal score is explained by a rise in abusive defamation lawsuits and legislative projects that have had a deterrent effect on news outlets.

In **Kazakhstan** (149th; -8), the country’s tightening legislation has been accompanied by indirect pressure on the media, repressive policies expanding into the online information space, and a climate of impunity for crimes against the press. **Kyrgyzstan** (146th) is also following this trend, notably due to weakened legal safeguards for journalists. At the very bottom of the ranking, **Belarus** (165th), **Azerbaijan** (171st), **Russia** (172nd) and **Turkmenistan** (173rd) have some of the lowest legal scores in the world, ranging between 22 and 32 points out of 100. In **Belarus** and **Russia** — which is the world’s second-largest prison for journalists and the largest for foreign reporters (all of whom are Ukrainian) — anti-terrorism and anti-extremism laws are regularly used to criminalise reporters’ work.

In this context, **Ukraine** (55th, +7) stands out as a relative exception, with a slight improvement in its overall score despite **Russia’s** war of aggression. This progress is notably due to the country’s dynamic media sector and the investigative work carried out by Ukrainian outlets to strengthen transparency in the country’s political life.

Inconsistent application of EU law by member states and candidate countries

Time, press freedom and the right to receive information are protected by the European Media Freedom Act (EMFA), which came into force in August 2025, many member states and candidate countries are in breach of it. In **Germany** (14th), national security laws do not meet the act's strict requirements regarding the protection of journalists and their sources. The EMFA's provisions that guarantee the independence of public service media outlets are being undermined by both existing regulatory frameworks and draft legislation, notably in **Bulgaria** (71st), **Malta** (67th), **Italy** (56th), **Slovakia** (37th), **France** (25th), **Lithuania** (15th) and **Czechia** (11th). **Estonia** (3rd), whose public broadcaster has not escaped pressures, has lost its position within the EU to the Netherlands (2nd). In **Hungary** (74th, -6), Viktor Orbán's outgoing government has refused to implement the EMFA, violated freedom of expression through the Sovereignty Protection Office – a tool for institutionalising the harassment of journalists – and politicised media regulation. It ranks among the three lowest EU countries, alongside **Cyprus** (80th) and **Greece** (86th), where European legislation has failed to address the "oligarchisation" of the media landscape and threats to journalists' safety.